

Rise of India's app ecosystem

India's app landscape has transformed dramatically over the last decade, fueled by ambitious government programs and a surge of homegrown entrepreneurship. In July 2015, Prime Minister Narendra Modi launched the **Digital India** initiative to build secure digital infrastructure, deliver government services electronically, and foster universal digital literacy.

Under this umbrella, projects like **BharatNet** extend high-speed fiber to rural gram panchayats, ensuring even remote villages gain reliable internet access. Complementing Digital India, the **Pradhan Mantri Gramin Digital Saksharta Abhiyan (PMG-DISHA)** has trained over **63.9 million rural citizens** in digital skills, empowering them to confidently access online services by March 2024.

Building on these foundations, the **Atmanirbhar Bharat App Innovation Challenge** was announced on July 4, 2020 via MyGov.in, inviting innovators to submit apps across nine categories – Office Productivity, Social Networking, E-Learning, Entertainment, Health & Wellness, Business (including AgriTech and FinTech), News, Games, and Others. Remarkably, the challenge drew **~7,000 submissions** from individuals and organizations nationwide, two-thirds hailing from Tier-II and Tier-III cities – underscoring the decentralization of India's tech talent.

Among the winners were **Kutuki** (an early-learning app), **AskSarkar** (an AI chatbot for government services), and **ShareChat** (a multilingual social network). These winners showcased India's capacity to deliver world-class mobile experiences – leveraging local language support, AI-driven personalization, and integration with national payment systems like UPI.

One early social-networking success story was **Koo**, a multilingual microblogging service that won attention in 2020. However, on July 3, 2024, Koo announced it would **cease operations** due to failed

partnership talks and high operational costs. In the wake of Koo's shutdown, users seeking a Made-in-India microblogging or community platform have gravitated toward **Kutumb**. Unlike traditional microblogging feeds, Kutumb organizes interactions around interests – making it easier to find relevant discussions in vernacular languages.

This pivot from Koo to Kutumb exemplifies India's resilient app ecosystem: when one service falters, another emerges to fulfill user needs in a more sustainable, community-oriented way.



By tracing the path from **Digital India** to **Atmanirbhar Bharat** to the **App Innovation Challenge**, these initiatives underscore a powerful narrative: India's digital transformation is not just about infrastructure – it's about empowering citizens to build and adopt solutions that understand their language, culture, and real-world needs.

As you explore the "Best Indian Apps" in the chapters ahead, remember that each app represents a collective effort to make India's digital ecosystem more inclusive, innovative, and self-reliant. Embrace these homegrown tools, and you'll not only enhance your daily life but also contribute to the nation's goal of technological sovereignty. 